

Chris Samarin

College of Information and Computer Sciences, University of Massachusetts Amherst

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Summary

PhD candidate in Information Retrieval at UMass Amherst (CIIR), advised by Hamed Zamani. My research spans conversational and agentic search, proactive language models, retrieval-augmented reasoning and generation, long-form factuality, and document ranking, with **11+ publications** at venues including SIGIR, ACL, NAACL, and ICTIR. I have completed research internships at **Netflix**, **Amazon**, and **Adobe**, and earlier worked across three AI startups in adtech, fintech, and biotech on contextual recommendation, concept and relation extraction, and large-scale fact-checking. Two-time Alexa Prize Taskbot participant (2021, 2022), **2nd place** at the 2026 Databricks Grounded Reasoning Cup, and former researcher at NUS, dedicated to advancing multimodal content organization and discovery.

Education

Ph.D. in Computer Science, University of Massachusetts Amherst September 2021 – 2026 (expected)
Conversational information seeking at CIIR; advisor: Hamed Zamani.

M.Sc. in Computer Science, University of Massachusetts Amherst September 2021 – 2023
Advisors: Hamed Zamani, Mohit Iyyer.

B.Sc. in Computer Science, Aristotle University of Thessaloniki October 2013 – June 2017
GPA 9.67/10.00, ranked 1/120 — highest in the department since 1992.

Publications & Preprints

(underlined = presenting / lead author)

Truncated Step-Level Sampling with Process Rewards for Retrieval-Augmented Reasoning
Chris Samarin, Hamed Zamani. *Preprint*, 2025

Plan-and-Refine: Diverse and Comprehensive Retrieval-Augmented Generation
Alireza Salemi, Chris Samarin, Hamed Zamani. *ICTIR 2026*

Distillation and Refinement of Reasoning in Small Language Models for Document Re-ranking
Chris Samarin, Hamed Zamani. *ICTIR 2025*

Beyond Factual Accuracy: Evaluating Coverage of Diverse Factual Information in Long-form Text Generation
Chris Samarin, Alexander Krubner, Alireza Salemi, Youngwoo Kim, Hamed Zamani. *ACL 2025*

Simulating Task-Oriented Dialogues with State Transition Graphs and Large Language Models
Chris Samarin, Pracha Promthaw, Atharva Nijasure, Hansi Zeng, Julian Killingback, Hamed Zamani. *Preprint*

ProCIS: A Benchmark for Proactive Retrieval in Conversations
Chris Samarin, Hamed Zamani. *SIGIR 2024*

Revisiting Open Domain Query Facet Extraction and Generation
Chris Samarin, Arkin Dharawat, Hamed Zamani. *ICTIR 2022*

Improving Evidence Retrieval for Automated Explainable Fact-Checking
Chris Samarin, Wynne Hsu, Mong Li Lee. *NAACL 2021 (System Demonstration)*

Latent Retrieval for Large-Scale Fact-Checking and Question Answering with NLI Training
Chris Samarin, Wynne Hsu, Mong Li Lee. *IEEE ICTAI 2020*

Research & Industry Experience

University of Massachusetts Amherst Research Assistant, CIIR Conversational & proactive IR, retrieval-augmented reasoning; Lead/Member, Alexa Prize Taskbot Challenges (2021, 2022).	September 2021 – Present
Netflix Machine Learning Research Intern Generative retrieval and re-ranking for conversational search (Interactive Discovery).	February 2025 – May 2025
Amazon Applied Scientist Intern Generative retrieval for conversational music search (Alexa Audio Search & Discovery).	Summer 2024 & 2025
Adobe Research Intern Multi-step query reformulation for dense retrieval (Real-time Experiences & Algorithms Lab).	June 2022 – December 2022
Ro5 Machine Learning Consultant (Knowledge Graph) Biomedical knowledge graph from research papers: entity extraction, entity resolution, relation classification (biotech).	February 2021 – August 2021
National University of Singapore Research Assistant Latent retrieval for large-scale fact-checking and QA; deployed a COVID-19 search engine launched by the NUS President.	February 2020 – April 2021
Plural AI Research Engineer (employee #1) Owned the full ML pipeline for a finance knowledge engine — concept extraction, category-graph curation, semantic search (fintech).	October 2018 – January 2020
Donaco LTD Research Engineer Contextual recommendation of charity campaigns in news articles (adtech).	June 2018 – January 2019

Awards & Honors

Grounded Reasoning Cup, 2nd Place — <i>Databricks; ahead of MIT, Columbia, Yale, UW, UIUC, UBC.</i>	2026
Bioengineering Hackathon, 1st Place — <i>EMB IEEE Student Chapter AUTH, StudentGuru.</i>	2018
Great Moment for Education Scholarship — <i>Eurobank Ergasias (highest national university-admission grade).</i>	2013
National Mathematical Olympiad, First Prize — <i>Hellenic Mathematical Society (top 50 of 20,000+).</i>	2009

Grants & Fellowships

Grounded Reasoning Cup, 2nd Place — <i>Databricks; \$30,000 in LLM credits for our agentic QA system.</i>	2026
Bodossaki Foundation PhD Scholarship — <i>\$60,000 for 5-year PhD studies in Information Retrieval.</i>	2021
SIGIR Travel Grant — <i>ACM SIGIR, for ICTIR 2022 (Madrid).</i>	2022
TensorFlow Research Cloud Program — <i>Google; free TPU-pod access for large-scale latent retrieval.</i>	2020
Innovate UK Smart Grant — <i>£400,000 (1% acceptance) for a finance knowledge engine at Plural AI.</i>	2019
Horizon 2020 Grant — <i>£50,000 (16% acceptance) for entity extraction and semantic search at Plural AI.</i>	2019

Service & Mentoring

Reviewer: SIGIR 2024, SIGIR 2025, COLM 2026, ACL (ARR), ACM TOIS.
Mentoring: Early Research Scholars Program (ERSP, 2022) and PhD Applicant Support Program at UMass; supervised 7 master's and 4 undergraduate students on research projects.